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ACCESS CONTROL OF ELECTRONIC DEVICE FEATURE USING A CERTIFICATE

Abstract

In some examples, a controller of an electronic device receives a certificate sent from an access device that is connected to the electronic device, the certificate including a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature of the electronic device, the certificate issued by a certificate authority, where the electronic device feature of the electronic device is initially blocked from access. The controller validates the certificate using the representation of the security key hierarchy in the memory. Responsive to the validation of the certificate, the controller enables access to the electronic device feature by the access device based on the feature control information element in the certificate.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND

[0001] Electronic devices can be deployed in computing environments such as data centers, cloud computing environments, or other computing environments. During the life of an electronic device, different people may have physical access to the electronic device, such as at a manufacturing or assembly site, during shipment of the electronic device to a target destination, and during use of the electronic device at the target destination.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0002] Some implementations of the present disclosure are described with respect to the following figures.

[0003] FIG. 1 is a block diagram of an arrangement that includes a server computer, an access device, and a public key infrastructure (PKI) including a certificate authority (CA), in accordance with some examples.

[0004] FIG. 2 is a block diagram of a process of certificate-based fine-grained access control of electronic device features of the server computer, according to some examples.

[0005] FIG. 3 is a block diagram depicting delegation of access permissions among users, according to some examples.

[0006] FIG. 4 is a block diagram of a PKI tree according to some examples.

[0007] FIG. 5 is a block diagram of an electronic device according to some examples.

[0008] FIG. 6 is a block diagram of a storage medium storing machine-readable instructions according to some examples.

[0009] FIG. 7 is a flow diagram of a process according to some examples.

[0010] Throughout the drawings, identical reference numbers designate similar, but not necessarily identical, elements. The figures are not necessarily to scale, and the size of some parts may be exaggerated to more clearly illustrate the example shown. Moreover, the drawings provide examples and/or implementations consistent with the description; however, the description is not limited to the examples and/or implementations provided in the drawings.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0011] Although security mechanisms and techniques have been implemented to protect programs and network communications of electronic devices, some electronic devices may still be subject to unauthorized physical access. Outside of tightly controlled physical facilities, electronic devices may be accessed at a manufacturing or assembly site, during shipment, after hours, or at remote sites (such as when a user is traveling or at any sites that are away from secure areas of an enterprise). In some cases, electronic devices of a first enterprise may be physically located at a colocation data center operated by a second enterprise. The second enterprise may rent physical space in the colocation data center for the electronic devices of the first enterprise.

[0012] An unauthorized user (e.g., a technician or any other user) may be able to connect (either using a wired connection or a wireless connection) portable devices to a target electronic device to obtain sensitive information from the target electronic device, including network addresses such as Internet Protocol (IP) addresses, user credentials, versions of programs in the target electronic device, and/or other sensitive information. The portable device once connected to the target electronic device may even be able to capture user inputs (e.g., inputs to a keyboard or touchscreen, pointer device inputs, etc.) entered by a user on a remote console that is coupled over a network to the target electronic device. Further, the portable device may be able to introduce malware into the

target electronic device to corrupt the target electronic device or to cause the target electronic device to perform unauthorized actions. An example of a portable device that can be connected to the target electronic device is a Universal Serial Bus (USB) device. Other types of portable devices include smartphones, tablet computers, notebook computers, or any other electronic device that can be carried by a user to the location of the target electronic device.

[0013] In accordance with some implementations of the present disclosure, a security key hierarchy (including a hierarchical arrangement of keys) is bound to a target electronic device (or more generally, to a collection of target electronic devices) that is to be protected against unauthorized physical access. As used here, a “collection” of items can refer to a single item or multiple items. Thus, a collection of target electronic devices can refer to a single target electronic device or multiple target electronic devices. An example of the security key hierarchy is a public key infrastructure (PKI) tree that has a hierarchical arrangement of keys representing entities of an enterprise. To bind the security key hierarchy to the target electronic device that is to be protected, a representation of the security key hierarchy is provided to a controller in the target electronic device to be protected. The controller can include a management controller such as a baseboard management controller (BMC). Certificates can be generated based on keys in the security key hierarchy to provide access control of certain features of a target electronic device. A certificate can include access control metadata that supports fine-grained access control of specific features of the target electronic device.

[0014] A “fine-grained” access control of a feature of the target electronic device refers to the ability to selectively enable or disable access to the feature by an access device. The fine-grained access control is distinguished from device-level access control in which overall access to the target electronic device is enabled or disabled. The fine-grained access control based on access control metadata of a certificate allows access to be disabled for a first feature of the target electronic device while access to a second feature of the target electronic device is enabled.

[0015] An enterprise can refer to an organization (e.g., a business concern, a government agency, an educational organization, a charitable organization, or any other organization) or an individual. Entities of the enterprise can include users (e.g., employees, contractors, personnel of third-party vendors, or other users) of the enterprise, segments of the enterprise (e.g., different departments of an organization), access devices that are to be used to access target electronic devices, or other types of entities. The security key hierarchy includes keys associated with respective entities associated with the enterprise. A key associated with an access device is used to provide fine grained access control of a target electronic device that is bound to the security key hierarchy. More specifically, the key associated with the access device can be used to obtain a security certificate (or more simply, a “certificate”) that includes access control metadata that can selectively control access to individual features of the target electronic device, such as a port (e.g., a USB port or another type of wired or wireless port) of the target electronic device, a display device of the target electronic device, a power cycling subsystem of the target electronic device (which controls power cycling of the target electronic device), a program of the target electronic device, a boot mechanism to boot the target electronic device, or any other feature.

[0016] Examples of electronic devices to be protected against unauthorized physical access can include computers such as server computers, desktop computers, notebook computers and tablet computers; storage systems; communication nodes; vehicles; or other types of electronic devices. Examples of access devices can include notebook computers, tablet computers, smartphones, USB devices, or other types of devices that when connected (by a wired connection or a wireless connection) to a target electronic device enables a user to access the target electronic device.

[0017] A “key” can refer to a collection of values (a single value or multiple values) that can be used to obtain a certificate to support secure access to a target electronic device. In some examples, a key can refer to a public-private key pair that includes a public key and the associated private key.

[0018] A “certificate” can refer to information that is used to secure communications, such as

between an access device and a target electronic device. In some examples, certificates can be X.509 certificates according to the X.509 protocol, which is provided by the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) and defines the format of public key certificates. An X.509 certificate binds an identity to a public key using a digital signature. A certificate contains an identity (a hostname, or an identity of an organization or an individual) and a public key, and the certificate can be signed by a certificate authority (CA). When a certificate is signed by a trusted CA, an entity holding the certificate can use the public key contained in the certificate to establish secure communications with another entity, such as to ensure that an access device that is connected to a target electronic device is authorized to access features of the target electronic device.

[0019] In accordance with some implementations of the present disclosure, a certificate such as an X.509 certificate is extended to add access control metadata, which can be in the form of object identifier (OID) metadata according to X.509, for example. The access control metadata can include one or more feature control information elements (in the form of values of OIDs, for example) that specify access permissions of electronic device features. A feature control information element if set to a first value disables access to an electronic device feature of a target electronic device, and if set to a different second value enables access to an electronic device feature of a target electronic device.

[0020] More specifically, an X.509 certificate includes an Extensions field, which is a sequence of one or more certificate extensions. Each certificate extension has its own unique identifier, expressed as an OID. An OID includes a set of values. In some examples of the present disclosure, one or more values of an OID can be used as a feature control information element (or more generally, access control metadata) to control access to an electronic device feature.

[0021] FIG. 1 is a block diagram of an example arrangement that includes a server computer **102**, an access device **104**, and a public key infrastructure (PKI) **105**. The server computer **102** is an example of a target electronic device with electronic device features that are to be selectively enabled or disabled using certificates according to some examples of the present disclosure.

[0022] The PKI **105** is an example of a system (implemented with one or more computers) that manages the issuance of certificates and the binding of target electronic devices, such as the server computer **102**, to a security key hierarchy (e.g., a PKI tree), to enable selective access control of electronic device features. The PKI **105** includes a certificate authority (CA) **106** that issues certificates.

[0023] Although just one server computer **102** and one access device **104** is depicted in FIG. 1, it is noted that there may be multiple server computers or other target electronic devices and multiple access devices. For example, a facility can include a large quantity of target electronic devices. Users with access devices can attempt to access electronic device features of the target electronic devices.

[0024] The server computer **102** includes a baseboard management controller (BMC) **108** and a host processor (or multiple host processors) **110**. The BMC **108** is an example of a management controller of the server computer **102** that is able to perform management tasks associated with the server computer **102**.

[0025] The host processor **110** is part of the processing resource of the server computer **102**. The host processor **110** executes primary machine-readable instructions of the server computer **102**, such as an operating system (OS) **112**, an application program **114**, system firmware **116**, or other software or firmware. A processor can include a microprocessor, a core of a multi-core microprocessor, a microcontroller, a programmable integrated circuit, a programmable gate array, or another hardware processing circuit.

[0026] The system firmware **116** can include Basic Input/Output System (BIOS) code or Universal Extensible Firmware Interface (UEFI) code, for example. “Primary” machine-readable instructions are distinct (and separate) from machine-readable instructions (such as firmware or software)

executable by other electronic components (separate from the host processor **110**). The primary machine-readable instructions may be stored in a storage medium (not shown in FIG. 1)

[0027] As used here, a “controller” can refer to one or more hardware processing circuits, which can include any or some combination of a microprocessor, a core of a multi-core microprocessor, a microcontroller, a programmable integrated circuit, a programmable gate array, or another hardware processing circuit. Alternatively, a “controller” can refer to a combination of one or more hardware processing circuits and machine-readable instructions (software and/or firmware) executable on one or more hardware processing circuits.

[0028] The server computer **102** includes various electronic device features. An access control engine **120** of the BMC **108** can selectively enable or disable access to the electronic device features based on a certificate presented to the BMC **108**, such as from the access device **104**. As used here, an “engine” can refer to one or more hardware processing circuits, which can include any or some combination of a microprocessor, a core of a multi-core microprocessor, a microcontroller, a programmable integrated circuit, a programmable gate array, or another hardware processing circuit. Alternatively, an “engine” can refer to a combination of one or more hardware processing circuits and machine-readable instructions (software and/or firmware) executable on the one or more hardware processing circuits.

[0029] The access control engine **120** can control fine-grained access control of the electronic device features, which can include a port **122** of the server computer **102**, a display device **124** of the server computer **102**, a power cycling subsystem of the server computer **102** (that can power off the server computer **102** followed by powering on the server computer **102**), a boot mechanism to boot the server computer **102**, and/or other features. An example of the port **122** is a USB port. In other examples, different types of ports may be employed. A “port” refers to an interface of an electronic device that is accessible by an external device (e.g., the access device **104**) to gain access to the electronic device. The port may perform wired or wireless communication with the external device. A port interface (IF) **123** is connected to the port **122** to communicate with the external device when the external device is connected to the port **122**. If access to the port **122** is disabled, then an external device such as the access device **104** would not be able to access portions of the server computer **102** through the port **122**. For example, the external device would not be able to access stored information in the server computer **102**, access programs or hardware components in the server computer **102**, monitor inputs from remote consoles that are coupled to the server computer **102**, and so forth.

[0030] As shown in FIG. 1, the display device **124** can display information **126**. In some cases, the information **126** displayed by the display device **124** of the server computer **102** may include sensitive information that should not be viewed by an unauthorized user. If access to the display device **124** is disabled, then the display device **124** may show a blank screen or may just show generic information that is not sensitive.

[0031] In some examples, the electronic device features of the server computer **102** are initially locked from access unless access to the electronic device features are enabled by the access control engine **120** of the BMC **108**. Effectively, the server computer **102** may be initially a “bricked” device, which refers to a device that is non-functional, due to the electronic device features being disabled. The locking of the electronic device features can be performed by a manufacturer of the server computer **102**, or by an administrator at a facility in which the server computer **102** is located, or by any other designated entity. While locked, no person can gain access to the server computer **102** without a certificate.

[0032] Access to the port **122** can be disabled (or locked) by shutting down the port IF **123** or configuring the port IF **123** (or alternatively, the host processor **110**) to be non-responsive to signals from an external device connected to the port **122**. Access to the display device **124** is disabled by configuring by shutting down the display device **124** or configuring a program or hardware component associated with the display device to prevent display of any information, or to allow

display of just generic information. Access to a power cycling subsystem of the server computer **102** can be disabled by blocking access to a power controller in the server computer **102**. The boot mechanism of the server computer **102** can be disabled by preventing a bootloader from being loaded in the server computer **102**.

[0033] The CA **106** is a trusted third-party that can be used to produce certificates that can allow entities, such as the access device **104**, to access electronic device features of the server computer **102** (and other target electronic devices).

[0034] The PKI **105** can set up (at **130**) a PKI tree **132** in the BMC **108**. The PKI tree **132** is stored in a memory **134** of the BMC **108**. The BMC **108** includes a network interface (NI) **135** that is connected to a management network. The PKI **105** can interact with the BMC **108** over the management network. The management network is a secondary network to which the server computer **102** is connected. The server computer **102** can include a network interface (not shown) that is connected to a primary network separate from the management network. The primary network is used by the server computer **102** to perform communications associated with normal operations of the server computer **102**, such as operations performed by the primary machine-readable instructions of the server computer **102**. “Normal” operations can refer to operations of the server computer **102** that are different from management operations of a management controller such as the BMC **108**.

[0035] Setting up the PKI tree **132** in the BMC **108** binds the PKI tree **132** to the server computer **102**. Once the PKI tree **132** is installed in the BMC **108**, the access control engine **120** can selectively enable or disable access to electronic device features of the server computer **102** based on certificates provided to the BMC **108** by external entities, such as the access device **104**. The certificates can be generated by the CA **106** based on keys that are represented in the PKI tree **132**.

[0036] The PKI tree **132** includes a hierarchical arrangement of nodes that represent different entities, including users, user groups, access devices, or other entities. Each node is associated with a key that is assigned to the entity. A key in the PKI tree **132** can include a public-private key pair that has a public key and the corresponding private key.

[0037] The access device **104** includes a processor **140** (or multiple processors) and a memory **143**. The processor **140** can execute an administrative program **142** that is used to perform various administrative tasks with respect to the server computer **102**, such as to perform maintenance, troubleshooting, repairs (including updates of machine-readable instructions of the server computer **102**), and so forth. The memory **143** stores a public key **144** that is associated with the access device **104**. The memory **143** can also store a private key **145** that is associated with the public key **144**. The memory **143** can be a secure memory that is part of a security processor of the access device **104**. An example of a security processor is a trusted platform module (TPM).

[0038] The access device **104** is used by a user **146**, which may be a technician or another type of user. Note that the public key **144** and the private key **145** can be keys assigned to the user **146**, to allow the user **146** to use the access device **104** to obtain a certificate **154** to gain access to electronic device features of the server computer **102**.

[0039] The memory **143** also stores an access credential **148**, such as a password, a personal identification number (PIN), biometric information, or any other credential that can be provided by the user **146** to gain access to the access device **104**. For example, to gain access to the access device **104**, the user **146** can enter a password or a PIN using an input device of the access device **104**. Alternatively, the access device **104** is able to receive biometric information of the user **146**, such as based on a camera performing facial recognition or a fingerprint scanner scanning a fingerprint of the user **146**.

[0040] If the user **146** wishes to access electronic device features (including the port **122** and/or the display device **124**) of the server computer **102**, in addition to inputting an access credential (to be matched to the stored access credential **148**), the user **146** also uses the access device **104** to obtain a certificate that is to be provided to the BMC **108** of the server computer **102**. In accordance with

some examples of the present disclosure, the access device **104** constitutes a multifactor access device that allows the user **146** to access an electronic device feature of the server computer **102** based on multiple factors, including the access credential **148** and use of a certificate derived from the public key **144** stored in the access device **104**.

[0041] In other examples, the user **146** does not have to be physically near the access device **104**. The user **146** may be remotely located from the access device **104**, but the user **146** may have another device that has wireless connectivity, such as over a WI-FI network or a cellular network, to the access device **104**. The remote user **146** can perform remote administration of the server computer **102** using the access device **104**, based on obtaining the certificate **154** from the CA **106** as discussed above.

Certificate-Based Fine-Grained Access Control

[0042] The following discussion refers to both FIG. 1 and FIG. 2. FIG. 2 is a flow diagram of a process of providing certificate-based fine-grained access control to electronic device features of the server computer **102**, in accordance with some examples of the present disclosure. In other examples, the tasks of the process can be performed in a different order from that depicted in FIG. 2, additional tasks may be added, and some tasks may be omitted.

[0043] To obtain a certificate, the user **146** can provide an input to the access device **104**, such as through a user interface (UI) of the access device **104**. The administrative program **142** receives (at **202**) the input for server computer access. In response to the input, the administrative program **142** sends (at **204**) an access request **152** to the CA **106** over a network. The access request **152** can include a certificate signing request (CSR), which is a request that seeks the issuance of a certificate. The CSR can contain the public key **144** of the access device **104**.

[0044] In response to the CSR, the CA **106** validates (at **206**) the access request. For example, the CSR may be signed by the access device **104** using the private key **145**. The CA **106** is able to successfully validate the CSR if the CSR is signed using a valid private key. In response to successful validation of the CSR, the CA **106** issues a certificate **154** that is sent (at **208**) from the CA **106** back to the access device **104**. In accordance with some examples of the present disclosure, the CA **106** includes a feature control information element (IE) **156** in the certificate **154**. The feature control information element **156** may be part of an OID of the certificate **154** (e.g., an X.509 certificate), for example. The feature control information element **156** can be set to one of several different values, which can specify whether or not the access device **104** is able to access a corresponding electronic device feature of the server computer **102** once the access device **104** is connected to the server computer **102** (e.g., a port **158** of the access device **104** is connected to the port **122** of the server computer **102**). In some cases, the certificate **154** can include multiple feature control information elements that correspond to different electronic device features of the server computer **102**.

[0045] Fine-grained access control based on feature control information elements of a certificate can be accomplished without the BMC **108** having to access a remote device to verify whether access should be granted. For example, even if the BMC **108** were to lose a network connection, fine-grained access control based on the certificate **154** presented by the access device **104** can still be performed.

[0046] To request access to one or more electronic device features of the server computer **102**, the administrative program **142** can send (at **210**), to the BMC **108**, the certificate **154**, such as through the port **122** of the server computer **102** or through another connection to the server computer **102**. The other connection may be an out-of-band connection to the NI **135** of the BMC **108**, for example. Note that the connection between the access device **104** and the BMC **108** is a zero trust connection; in other words, just because the access device **104** is able to connect to the BMC **108** does not mean that the access device **104** can be trusted. Rather, the trust is established using the certificate **154**.

[0047] The access control engine **120** receives the certificate **154** from the access device **104**.

Based on the certificate **154**, the access control engine **120** can determine whether or not to grant access to one or more of the electronic device features of the server computer **102** to the access device **104**.

[0048] In some examples, the certificate **154** sent from the access device **104** to the BMC **108** is signed using the private key **145** of the access device **104**. The access control engine **120** can validate (at **212**) the certificate **154**, such as by using the public key of the access device **104** to decrypt the signed certificate **154**. The public key of the access device **104** can be obtained by the access control engine **120** from the PKI tree **132**.

[0049] In some examples, in addition to presenting the certificate **154**, the administrative program **142** in the access device **104** can further send, to the BMC **108**, a message (e.g., a data packet) that contains a current timestamp (from a time clock in the access device **104**). The message containing the current timestamp is signed by the private key **145** of the access device **104**. A reason to send the message containing the current timestamp signed with the private key **145** is to prevent a replay attack in which an unauthorized entity that has obtained the certificate can replay the same certificate repeatedly to gain access to the server computer **102**. The current timestamp serves as an indication to the access control engine **120** in the BMC **108** that the signed certificate is not too old. In other examples, the access control engine **120** can issue a challenge to the access device **104** to avoid a replay attack. The validation of the certificate **154** is thus further based on validating the message containing the current timestamp, or receiving a valid response to the challenge issued by the access control engine **120** to the access device **104**.

[0050] If the access control engine **120** is able to successfully validate the certificate **154** from the access device **104**, the access control engine **120** retrieves (at **214**) the feature control information element **156** from the certificate **154**, and determines (at **216**), based on the value assigned the feature control information element **156** in the certificate **154**, whether a corresponding electronic device feature of the server computer **102** is to be enabled or disabled.

[0051] If the value assigned the feature control information element **156** in the certificate **154** specifies that access to the corresponding electronic device feature is enabled, the access control engine **120** grants access (at **218**) to the corresponding electronic device feature. The access control engine **120** can send (at **220**) an accept indication to the access device **104**, where the accept indication can indicate that access to the corresponding electronic device feature has been granted. The accept indication can include a message, an information element, a signal, or any other indicator. For example, the accept indication can be in the form of the corresponding electronic device feature responding positively to the access attempt by the access device **104** (e.g., by allowing the access device **104** to access the corresponding electronic device feature).

[0052] If the value assigned the feature control information element **156** in the certificate **154** specifies that access to the corresponding electronic device feature is disabled, the access control engine **120** disables access (at **222**) to the corresponding electronic device feature. The access control engine **120** can send (at **224**) a reject indication to the access device **104**, where the reject indication can indicate that access to the corresponding electronic device feature has been denied. The reject indication can include a message, an information element, a signal, or any other indicator. For example, the reject indication can be in the form of the server computer **102** responding with an error or not responding at all to the access attempt by the access device **104**.

[0053] In some examples, the certificate **154** can have multiple feature control information elements **156**, including a first feature control information element for the port **122** and a second feature control information element for the display device **124**. The first feature control information element can specify whether access to the port **122** is enabled (or disabled), and the second feature control information element can specify whether access to the display device **124** is enabled (or disabled).

[0054] If a feature control information element of the certificate **154** specifies that access to a respective electronic device feature is enabled, the access control engine **120** provides an indication

to an entity (e.g., the host processor **110** or a program executed by the host processor **110**) that access to the respective electronic device feature is enabled, so the entity can configure the respective electronic device feature to enable the access.

[0055] On the other hand, if the feature control information element of the certificate **154** specifies that access to the respective electronic device feature is disabled, the access control engine **120** can keep the respective electronic device feature in an access disabled state. Note that in some examples, the electronic device features of the server computer **102** are initially locked from access, such that the electronic device features cannot be accessed absent provision of a valid certificate from an access device.

[0056] In some examples, a certificate, such as the certificate **154**, has an expiry time, after which the certificate is no longer valid. For example, the certificate **154** may include an expiry time information element that specifies either a time duration from an issue time of the certificate **154** after which the certificate **154** is considered expired, or a set time at which the certificate **154** is considered expired. Once a certificate is expired, a user or access device would no longer be able to use the expired certificate to access an electronic device feature of the server computer **102**. The time duration during which a certificate is valid can be on the order of hours, days, months, or other time lengths.

[0057] The PKI **105** can revoke an issued certificate at any point in time. For example, the PKI **105** can distribute a certificate revocation list to the server computer **102** (and to other target electronic devices) that includes identifiers of certificates that have been revoked. The access control engine **120** can check the certificate revocation list before validating a certificate. If the certificate is identified in the certificate revocation list, then the access control engine **120** can reject the attempted access to the electronic device feature. Note that when a given certificate is revoked, any certificates that depend from the given certificate are also revoked (e.g., a certificate of a department head being revoked would revoke the certificates of the entire department).

Access Rights Delegation

[0058] An enterprise, such as the enterprise that operates or manages a collection of server computers and/or other electronic devices, may include a number of users. In accordance with some examples of the present disclosure, different users (or different groups of users) may be assigned different access roles with respect to accessing electronic devices of the enterprise.

[0059] For example, a first class of user is an executive user (or “superuser”), who is assigned the highest access role (a role with the greatest access rights to electronic devices). The executive user (such as a system administrator for the enterprise) may be granted a highest level of access to electronic devices. In addition, the executive user may be able to delegate rights to other classes of users with lesser access roles (roles with decreased access rights to electronic devices).

[0060] The following discussion refers to FIG. 3 and FIG. 4. FIG. 3 is a block diagram illustrating different classes of users, including an executive user **302**, a programmer **304**, and a technician **306**. FIG. 4 is a block diagram of a PKI tree **400**, which can be an example of the PKI tree **132** of FIG. 1.

[0061] The executive user **302** has a user device **303**, the programmer **304** has a user device **305**, and the technician **306** has a user device **307**. A “user device” can refer to a computer or any other type of electronic device used by a user.

[0062] An enterprise that the users are part of includes a root certificate **300**. The root certificate **300** is represented by the root **402** of the PKI tree **400**. Note that the root certificate **300** can correspond to the overall enterprise, and thus the root **402** of the PKI tree **400** can represent the enterprise.

[0063] One or more lower level nodes in the PKI tree **400** can depend from the root **402**. For example, a node **404** depends from the root **402**, and the node **404** can represent the executive user **302**. In some examples, the executive user **302** can delegate access rights to the programmer **304** and the technician **306**. The programmer **304** is represented by a node **406** that depends from the

node **404**, and the technician **306** is represented by a node **408** that depends from the node **404**. Other nodes in the PKI tree **400** can represent other users. Nodes of the PKI tree **400** can also represent departments or other groups within the enterprise. Additionally, nodes of the PKI tree **400** can represent devices and other resources, such as electronic devices that are to be protected.

[0064] A certificate **312** can be issued to the user **302**, and the certificate **312** can be stored in the user device **303** associated with the user **302**. The certificate **312** can be signed using a private key associated with the root certificate. The signed root certificate forms the certificate **312** that is issued to the user **302**. The certificate **312** can include feature control information elements **322** (e.g., OID values of an X.509 certificate) that can specify a first collection of access permissions to access electronic device features of target electronic devices. In some examples, the certificate **312** can have a relatively long expiry time **332**, which may be one year or some other time length.

[0065] The executive user **302** can in turn delegate subsets of the first collection of access permissions to other users, including the programmer **304** and the technician **306**. For example, the programmer **304** can cause the user device **305** to send a CSR containing the programmer's public key to the user device **303** of the executive user **302**. The user device **303** can include a CA that can respond to the CSR from the user device **305** by sending a certificate **314** containing feature control information elements **324** specifying a second collection of access permissions, which may be a first subset of the first collection of access permissions specified in the certificate **312** for the executive user **302**. The certificate **314** for the programmer **304** can have an expiry time **334**, which can be relatively short (e.g., a few days or another time length).

[0066] The technician **306** can cause the user device **307** to send a CSR containing the technician's public key to the user device **303** of the executive user **302**. The CA in the user device **303** can respond to the CSR from the user device **307** by sending a certificate **316** containing feature control information elements **326** specifying a third collection of access permissions, which may be a second subset of the first collection of access permissions specified in the certificate **312** for the executive user **302**. The third collection of access permissions may be the same as or different from the second collection of access permissions. The certificate **316** for the technician **306** can have an expiry time **336**, which can be relatively short (e.g., a few hours or another time length). Note that the programmer **304** and the technician **306** do not have the ability to delegate access rights to other users.

[0067] In further examples, other users besides the executive user **302** can delegate access rights to further users.

Further Examples

[0068] FIG. **5** is a block diagram of an electronic device **500** that is to be protected using techniques or mechanisms according to some examples of the present disclosure. An example of the electronic device **500** is the server computer **102** of FIG. **1**.

[0069] The electronic device **500** includes a memory **502** to store a representation of a security key hierarchy **504**. An example of the security key hierarchy is a PKI tree. Storing the representation of a security key hierarchy **504** in the electronic device **500** binds the security key hierarchy to the electronic device **500**, so that certificate-based fine-grained access control can be used to selectively control electronic device features of the electronic device **500**.

[0070] The electronic device **500** a controller **506**, which can be a BMC or another type of management controller. The controller **506** can perform various tasks.

[0071] The tasks of the controller **506** include a certificate reception task **508** to receive a certificate sent from an access device (e.g., **104** in FIG. **1**) that is connected to the electronic device **500**. The certificate includes a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature of the electronic device **500**. The certificate issued by a CA, and the electronic device feature of the electronic device is initially blocked from access.

[0072] The tasks of the controller **506** include a certificate validation task **510** to validate the certificate using the representation of the security key hierarchy in the memory. For example, the

certificate may be signed by a private key stored in the access device. The validation of the signed certificate uses a public key retrieved from the representation of a security key hierarchy **504**. For example, the retrieved public key is the public key associated with the access device (or the user of the access device) as represented by a node in the security key hierarchy.

[0073] The tasks of the controller **506** include an access enablement task **512** to, responsive to the validation of the certificate, enable access to the electronic device feature by the access device based on the feature control information element in the certificate. In some examples, the feature control information element is part of an OID in the certificate.

[0074] In some examples, the OID includes metadata in which the feature control information element is settable to different values to indicate whether the electronic device feature is accessible.

[0075] In some examples, the electronic device feature remains blocked from access in an absence of a valid certificate.

[0076] In some examples, the electronic device feature includes a communication port of the electronic device, and the feature control information element provides access control of the communication port. An example of the communication port is the port **122** of FIG. **1**.

[0077] In some examples, the certificate received at the electronic device is signed by a private key associated with the access device, and the certificate issued by the certificate authority is based on a public key that is associated with the private key.

[0078] In some examples, the certificate includes expiry information indicating when the certificate expires.

[0079] In some examples, the controller **506** receives, from the access device, a message containing a timestamp, the message signed with a private key of the access device. The controller **506** uses the message as part of validating the certificate.

[0080] FIG. **6** is a block diagram of a non-transitory machine-readable or computer-readable storage medium **600** storing machine-readable instructions that upon execution cause an access device to perform various tasks. An example of the access device is the access device **104** of FIG. **1**.

[0081] The machine-readable instructions include access request sending instructions **602** to send, from the access device to a CA, an access request associated with accessing a target electronic device to which the access device is connected. The access device may be connected to the target electronic device by a wired connection or a wireless connection. The access request can include a CSR containing a public key associated with the access device (or a user of the access device).

[0082] The machine-readable instructions include certificate reception instructions **604** to receive, at the access device from the CA, a certificate as a response to the access request, the certificate including a feature control information element that provides fine-grained access control of an electronic device feature of the target electronic device. The certificate may include multiple feature control information elements that provide fine-grained access control of respective multiple electronic device features of the target electronic device.

[0083] The machine-readable instructions include certificate signing instructions **606** to sign the certificate using a private key stored in the access device.

[0084] The machine-readable instructions include signed certificate sending instructions **608** to send the signed certificate to a controller in the target electronic device. The controller may include a BMC or another type of management controller.

[0085] The machine-readable instructions include access indication reception instructions **610** to receive, at the access device from the target electronic device, an indication of whether access to the electronic device feature is granted. The indication may be the accept indication sent at **220** in FIG. **2**, or the reject indication sent at **224** in FIG. **2**.

[0086] FIG. **7** is a flow diagram of a process **700**, which may be performed by an electronic device.

[0087] The process **700** includes receiving (at **702**), at a controller (e.g., **108** in FIG. **1**) in the electronic device, a signed certificate sent from an access device that is connected to the electronic

device. The certificate includes a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature in the electronic device, where the certificate is issued by a certificate authority, and the electronic device feature of the electronic device is initially blocked from access. The electronic device further includes a host processor (e.g., **110** in FIG. **1**), separate from the controller, to execute primary machine-readable instructions of the electronic device. [0088] The process **700** includes validating (at **704**) the signed certificate using a public key from a representation of a security key hierarchy in a memory of the electronic device. The public key is included in a node of the security key hierarchy that represents the access device (or the user of the access device).

[0089] The process **700** includes enabling (at **706**) access, in response to a validation of the certificate, to the electronic device feature by the access device based on the feature control information element in the certificate.

[0090] A “BMC” (e.g., the BMC **108** of FIG. **1**) can refer to a specialized service controller that monitors the physical state of an electronic device using sensors and communicates with a remote management system (that is remote from the electronic device) through an independent “out-of-band” connection. The BMC can perform management tasks to manage components of the electronic device. Examples of management tasks that can be performed by the BMC can include any or some combination of the following: power control to perform power management of the electronic device (such as to transition the electronic device between different power consumption states in response to detected events), thermal monitoring and control of the electronic device (such as to monitor temperatures of the electronic device and to control thermal management states of the electronic device), fan control of fans in the electronic device, system health monitoring based on monitoring measurement data from various sensors of the electronic device, remote access to the electronic device (to access the electronic device over a network, for example), remote reboot of the electronic device (to trigger the computer system to reboot using a remote command), system setup and deployment of the electronic device, system security to implement security procedures in the electronic device, and so forth.

[0091] In some examples, the BMC can provide so-called “lights-out” functionality for an electronic device. The lights out functionality may allow a user, such as a systems administrator, to perform management operations on the electronic device even if an OS is not installed or not functional on the electronic device.

[0092] Moreover, in some examples, the BMC can run on auxiliary power provided by an auxiliary power supply (e.g., a battery); as a result, the electronic device does not have to be powered on to allow the BMC to perform the BMC's operations. The auxiliary power supply is separate from a main power supply that supplies powers to other components (e.g., a main processor, a memory, an input/output (I/O) device, etc.) of the electronic device.

[0093] A storage medium (e.g., **600** in FIG. **6**) can include any or some combination of the following: a semiconductor memory device such as a dynamic or static random access memory (a DRAM or SRAM), an erasable and programmable read-only memory (EPROM), an electrically erasable and programmable read-only memory (EEPROM) and flash memory; a magnetic disk such as a fixed, floppy and removable disk; another magnetic medium including tape; an optical medium such as a compact disk (CD) or a digital video disk (DVD); or another type of storage device. Note that the instructions discussed above can be provided on one computer-readable or machine-readable storage medium, or alternatively, can be provided on multiple computer-readable or machine-readable storage media distributed in a large system having possibly plural nodes. Such computer-readable or machine-readable storage medium or media is (are) considered to be part of an article (or article of manufacture). An article or article of manufacture can refer to any manufactured single component or multiple components. The storage medium or media can be located either in the machine running the machine-readable instructions, or located at a remote site from which machine-readable instructions can be downloaded over a network for execution.

[0094] In the present disclosure, use of the term “a,” “an,” or “the” is intended to include the plural forms as well, unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. Also, the term “includes,” “including,” “comprises,” “comprising,” “have,” or “having” when used in this disclosure specifies the presence of the stated elements, but do not preclude the presence or addition of other elements. [0095] In the foregoing description, numerous details are set forth to provide an understanding of the subject disclosed herein. However, implementations may be practiced without some of these details. Other implementations may include modifications and variations from the details discussed above. It is intended that the appended claims cover such modifications and variations.

Claims

1. An electronic device comprising: a memory to store a representation of a security key hierarchy; a controller to: receive a certificate sent from an access device that is connected to the electronic device, the certificate comprising a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature of the electronic device, the certificate issued by a certificate authority, wherein the electronic device feature of the electronic device is initially blocked from access; validate the certificate using the representation of the security key hierarchy in the memory; and responsive to the validation of the certificate, enable access to the electronic device feature by the access device based on the feature control information element in the certificate.
2. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the feature control information element is part of an object identifier (OID) in the certificate.
3. The electronic device of claim 2, wherein the OID comprises metadata, the metadata comprising the feature control information element settable to different values to indicate whether the electronic device feature is accessible.
4. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the electronic device feature remains blocked from access in an absence of a valid certificate.
5. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the electronic device feature comprises a communication port of the electronic device, and the feature control information element provides access control of the communication port.
6. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the electronic device feature comprises a display device of the electronic device, and the feature control information element provides access control of the display device.
7. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the electronic device feature comprises a power cycling subsystem or a boot mechanism of the electronic device, and the feature control information element provides access control of the power cycling subsystem or the boot mechanism.
8. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the certificate is signed with a private key of the access device, and the controller is to: validate the certificate based on decrypting the signed certificate using a public key obtained from the security key hierarchy.
9. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the security key hierarchy comprises a public key infrastructure (PKI) tree.
10. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the certificate received at the electronic device is signed by a private key associated with the access device, and the certificate issued by the certificate authority is based on a public key that is associated with the private key.
11. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the enabling of the access to the electronic device feature based on the feature control information element in the certificate comprises unblocking access to the electronic device feature that is initially blocked.
12. The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the security key hierarchy comprises a hierarchical arrangement of keys associated with respective entities, the entities comprising the electronic device and a user authorized to access the electronic device.

- 13.** The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the feature control information element if set to a first value disables access to the electronic device feature, and if set to a different second value enables access to the electronic device feature.
- 14.** The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the certificate comprises expiry information indicating when the certificate expires.
- 15.** The electronic device of claim 1, wherein the controller is to: receive a message containing a timestamp, the message signed with a private key of the access device; and use the message as part of validating the certificate.
- 16.** A non-transitory machine-readable storage medium comprising instructions that upon execution cause an access device to: send, from the access device to a certificate authority, an access request associated with accessing a target electronic device to which the access device is connected; receive, at the access device from the certificate authority, a certificate as a response to the access request, the certificate comprising a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature of the target electronic device; sign the certificate using a private key stored in the access device; send the signed certificate to a controller in the target electronic device; and receive, at the access device from the target electronic device, an indication of whether access to the electronic device feature is granted.
- 17.** The non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 16, wherein the indication is based on a validation of the signed certificate using a public key from a security key hierarchy represented in the target electronic device.
- 18.** The non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 17, wherein the validation of the signed certificate is performed by a management controller in the target electronic device, and the indication is received at the access device from the management controller.
- 19.** A method comprising: receiving, at a controller in an electronic device, a signed certificate sent from an access device that is connected to the electronic device, the certificate comprising a feature control information element that provides access control of an electronic device feature in the electronic device, the certificate issued by a certificate authority, wherein the electronic device feature of the electronic device is initially blocked from access, and wherein the electronic device further comprises a host processor, separate from the controller, to execute primary machine-readable instructions of the electronic device; validating, by the controller, the signed certificate using a public key from a representation of a security key hierarchy in a memory of the electronic device; and based on a validation of the signed certificate, enabling access to the electronic device feature by the access device based on the feature control information element in the certificate.
- 20.** The method of claim 19, wherein the certificate comprises an X.509 certificate, and the feature control information element is in an object identifier (OID) of the X.509 certificate.
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